

Cleaner Interview Questions & Scoring Rubric

The Cleaning CEO Blueprint — 100% Cleaner Academy

Use this guide to run consistent, professional interviews for residential cleaning candidates. Score each answer 1–5 and total at the end. **Minimum passing score: 70/100** (adjust for your standards).

How to Use This Guide

1. **Phone screen first** (10–15 min) — filter before in-person or working interview
2. **In-person or video interview** (30–45 min) — use questions below
3. **Paid trial clean** (2–3 hours) — observe quality, speed, communication, and attitude
4. Score immediately after each stage while notes are fresh

Scoring Scale

Score	Meaning
5	Excellent — exceeds expectations, specific examples
4	Good — solid answer, minor gaps
3	Acceptable — adequate but generic
2	Weak — red flags or vague responses
1	Poor — disqualifying or dishonest

Section 1: Experience & Skills (25 points)

1. Tell me about your cleaning experience. What types of homes have you cleaned?

What you're listening for: Residential experience, variety of home sizes, honesty about skill level.

Score	Criteria
5	2+ years residential, specific examples (deep cleans, move-outs, recurring)

3	Some experience, mostly commercial or personal only
1	No experience and unwilling to learn

2. Walk me through how you would clean a bathroom from start to finish.

What you're listening for: Systematic approach — top to bottom, disinfect high-touch areas, proper product use.

Score	Criteria
5	Clear sequence: dust/vents → surfaces → toilet → shower/tub → mirrors → floor last
3	General steps but misses disinfection or order
1	No logical process

3. What's the difference between a regular maintenance clean and a deep clean?

What you're listening for: Understanding of scope — baseboards, inside appliances, detail work vs. surface maintenance.

Score	Criteria
5	Names 5+ deep-clean tasks not in regular cleans
3	Knows deep is "more thorough" but can't specify
1	No distinction

4. How do you handle pet hair, heavy grease, or soap scum buildup?

What you're listening for: Product knowledge, patience, technique — not just "scrub harder."

Score	Criteria
5	Mentions degreasers, enzyme cleaners, microfiber, dwell time, tools
3	Willing to tackle but limited technique
1	Avoids difficult jobs

5. Are you comfortable with laundry, making beds, and light organizing?

What you're listening for: Flexibility for add-on services common in residential cleaning.

Score	Criteria
5	Comfortable with all; gives examples
3	Some tasks only
1	Refuses common add-ons

Section 2: Reliability & Work Ethic (25 points)

6. What does your weekly availability look like? Any blackout days?

What you're listening for: Realistic schedule that matches your booking volume.

Score	Criteria
5	Clear availability, open to weekends if needed, minimal conflicts
3	Limited days but workable
1	Unavailable when you need coverage most

7. How do you handle it when you're running behind schedule?

What you're listening for: Communication first — texts/calls owner, doesn't ghost clients.

Score	Criteria
5	Communicates immediately, adjusts pace, documents delay
3	Would try to catch up but may not communicate
1	Would not tell anyone

8. Tell me about a time you had to call off work. How did you handle it?

What you're listening for: Advance notice, accountability, backup mindset.

Score	Criteria
5	Gave maximum notice, offered to help find coverage
3	Called off but with reasonable notice
1	No-showed or last-minute pattern

9. This job requires driving to client homes. Do you have reliable transportation?

What you're listening for: Valid license, insured vehicle, realistic commute range.

Score	Criteria
5	Owns reliable car, valid license/insurance, comfortable driving 30+ min
3	Transportation exists but may be unreliable
1	No transportation

10. How do you stay motivated during repetitive work?

What you're listening for: Pride in results, client satisfaction, personal goals — not just a paycheck.

Score	Criteria
5	Takes pride in visible results, enjoys helping people
3	Neutral — it's a job
1	Clearly disengaged

Section 3: Customer Service & Communication (20 points)

11. A client says you're missing spots every visit. How do you respond?

What you're listening for: Professionalism, no defensiveness, willingness to fix and improve.

Score	Criteria
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5	Apologizes, asks specifics, re-cleans area, documents for next visit
3	Would fix it but may get defensive
1	Blames client or argues

12. A client asks you to use their products instead of yours. What do you do?

What you're listening for: Follows company policy, communicates with owner if unsure.

Score	Criteria
5	Checks with manager first; understands liability and allergy concerns
3	Would probably comply without asking
1	Refuses rudely or ignores policy

13. How comfortable are you texting updates and sending photos to the office during jobs?

What you're listening for: Tech comfort for GPS check-ins, arrival photos, completion photos.

Score	Criteria
5	Comfortable with smartphone apps, photos, group chats
3	Basic texting only
1	No smartphone or refuses documentation

14. Would you be comfortable working in homes while clients are present?

What you're listening for: Professional boundaries, comfort in occupied homes.

Score	Criteria
5	Professional, respectful, focused on work
3	Prefer empty homes but will adapt
1	Uncomfortable or inappropriate boundaries

Section 4: Integrity & Safety (20 points)

15. A client offers you cash to clean for them privately, off the books. What do you do?

What you're listening for: Loyalty, honesty, understanding of business relationship.

Score	Criteria
5	Declines immediately, reports to owner
3	Unsure what they'd do
1	Would accept

16. You accidentally break something in a client's home. What's your process?

What you're listening for: Immediate honesty, documentation, no hiding damage.

Score	Criteria
5	Notifies client and owner immediately, documents with photos
3	Would tell someone eventually
1	Would hide or leave without saying

17. How do you handle keys, gate codes, and client privacy?

What you're listening for: Security awareness, confidentiality, no sharing codes.

Score	Criteria
5	Never shares codes, secures keys, doesn't discuss clients
3	Generally careful
1	Casual attitude toward access credentials

18. Are you comfortable with a background check?

What you're listening for: Transparency — hesitation isn't always disqualifying, but evasiveness is.

Score	Criteria
5	Fully agrees, understands why it's required
3	Agrees with questions
1	Refuses or becomes defensive

Section 5: Fit & Expectations (10 points)

19. Why do you want to work with our company instead of cleaning independently?

What you're listening for: Values steady work, support, brand — not just "I need money."

Score	Criteria
5	Wants team support, consistent clients, professional structure
3	Generic answer
1	Only interested in stealing clients

20. What are your pay expectations?

What you're listening for: Alignment with your pay structure (\$100 regular / \$200 deep model or your rates).

Score	Criteria
5	Expectations match your model; understands per-job pay
3	Slightly high but negotiable
1	Expects hourly wage well above your margins

21. How do you feel about quality inspections and photo documentation?

What you're listening for: Accountability mindset — inspections are standard, not personal attacks.

Score	Criteria
5	Welcomes feedback, sees photos as protection
3	Tolerates it
1	Hostile to oversight

22. Where do you see yourself in one year?

What you're listening for: Retention potential — even "leading a team" shows ambition aligned with growth.

Score	Criteria
5	Wants to grow with company (lead cleaner, trainer)
3	Just wants stable work
1	Temporary until something else

23. Do you have any physical limitations we should know about? (Allergies, lifting, etc.)

What you're listening for: Honesty for safety — note: ask legally appropriate questions per your state's hiring laws.

Score	Criteria
5	Honest disclosure, can still perform core duties
3	Minor limitations with workarounds
1	Cannot perform essential job functions

24. Can you pass a paid trial clean this week? What day works?

What you're listening for: Commitment and scheduling flexibility.

Score	Criteria
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5	Available within 7 days, enthusiastic
3	Available within 2 weeks
1	Unwilling to do trial

25. Do you have any questions for me?

What you're listening for: Engagement — good candidates ask about training, pay schedule, expectations.

Score	Criteria
5	Thoughtful questions about SOPs, pay, growth
3	Basic questions only
1	No questions

Trial Clean Evaluation (Separate Scorecard)

Use this during the paid working interview. **Pass: 35+/50**

Criteria	1	2	3	4	5
Arrived on time					
Followed SOP / checklist					
Quality of bathroom clean					
Quality of kitchen clean					
Speed (reasonable for scope)					
Used products correctly					
Sent arrival/completion photos					
Professional with client/staff					
Left home secure (locks, lights)					
Overall hire recommendation					

Red Flags — Do Not Hire

- Refuses background check without valid legal reason
 - Badmouths every former employer
 - Cannot explain basic cleaning sequence
 - Shows up late to interview without notice
 - Trial clean quality below your minimum standard
 - Discusses stealing clients or working "on the side"
 - Unwilling to follow company SOPs or use required products
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Interview Score Summary

Section	Max Points	Score
Experience & Skills	25	
Reliability & Work Ethic	25	
Customer Service	20	
Integrity & Safety	20	
Fit & Expectations	10	
Total	100	

Decision:

- **85–100:** Strong hire — extend offer after trial
 - **70–84:** Hire with extra training and close supervision
 - **Below 70:** Do not hire
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Customize questions for your state hiring laws. Document consistently. 100% Cleaner / The Cleaning CEO Blueprint.